▼ GLASSHOUSE



SHADE OF SAFFRON

The acquittal of all seven accused in the 2006 Malegaon blast case by a special NIA court on July 31 has put the spotlight back on two once-powerful officers. As Union home secretary in 2013, R.K. Singh had backed the UPA's claims of right-wing extremist involvement; indeed, Congress spokesperson Shama Mohamed says he had coined the term "saffron terror". Ironically, RK later joined the BJP and was a Union minister (2019-24). His defence now is that he was only repeating what the NIA told him. Meanwhile, former ATS officer Mehboob Mujawar has alleged that then ACP Param Bir Singh had ordered the arrest of RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat in the case. Param Bir, who rose to become Mumbai police commissioner and was later suspended in an extortion case, got a clean chit in 2022 when the Shiv Sena (Shinde)-BJP government revoked his suspension. Guess your fate depends on which side of history you are on.

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ WASHINGTON LOBBY

PAYNE POINT

Stephen Payne, a Bush-era Republican lobbyist with deep West Asia connections, has emerged as Islamabad's go-to man in Washington—and a growing headache for New Delhi. Since landing a $1.5 million-a-year contract with Pakistan's Islamabad Policy Research Institute in October 2024, Payne has quietly steered Islamabad's D.C. narrative, especially during Operation Sindoor. With back



channels to Trumpworld, he has shaped talking points on Afghanistan, arms and the diaspora, often leaving South Block scrambling. From oil exploration buzz to crypto-friendly pitches to even a Nobel Peace Prize plug for Pakistan, Payne's is believed to be the invisible hand. The showstopper Trump-Gen. Asim Munir lunch? That was his masterstroke. Indian lobbyists are now under pressure to deliver.